The Praise of the Earliest Dawn

Suprabhātastotra · Toh 1167 · Derge Tengyur
རབ་ཏུ་སྒྲུབ་ཅིང་ནམ་ལངས་པའི་བསྟོད་པ།

The Praise of the Earliest Dawn, known in Sanskrit as the Suprabhātastotra and in Tibetan as Rabtu Ngawar Namlangpé Töpa, is a hymn in verse to the Buddha, which its colophon ascribes to Śrī Harṣadeva, king of Kashmir. In the manner of an Indian dawn hymn, it pictures one by one the great gods and sages of the Indian world, Brahmā, Śiva with Pārvatī, Indra, Viṣṇu, Agni, Balarāma, Gaṇeśa, and Kārttikeya, along with the sun, the moon, and famous ascetics and philosophers, as lost in sleep, drunkenness, or desire, while each verse closes with the refrain that the Buddha, who possesses the ten powers, is always awake at the earliest hour. The praise ends by honoring the Buddha as the one who stays awake while beings sleep in the night of ignorance, likening his qualities to water that a hundred herds of cattle can drink without lessening, and wishing that all beings may find the path and gain every accomplishment. It is Toh 1167 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the collection of praises (stotra), and it was translated into Tibetan by the Indian paṇḍita Rājaśrījñānamitra and the translator Kheu Gé Yönten Pal.

In Sanskrit: suprabhata prabhata stotraṃ
In Tibetan: The Praise of the Earliest Dawn

Homage to the Lord of the Three Worlds.

Though the hosts of gods, the siddhas, the chiefs of the gandharvas, and the lords of ascetics
Have praised him with every kind of hymn, in the domain of the gods and upon the earth,
I too, as far as I am able, shall praise the noble, perfect Buddha.
The garuḍa flies through the sky, it is said; why then should the bees not fly?

You who have cast off all that opposes, your faults exhausted without remainder,
Golden in hue like refined gold, with eyes wide as a lotus in full bloom,
Glorious, with a beautiful maṇḍala of light, encircled by the hosts of the gods:
For you who possess the ten powers, it is always the earliest dawn.

You who are victorious over the army of Māra and cut off the path of misery,
Who bring benefit to the three worlds and tear apart the three nets of

creepers,
Who strive to bring the bliss of peace and destroy the mountain of ignorance:
For you who possess the ten powers, it is always the earliest dawn.

He who, even before the asuras, humans, and gods, attained the abode of bliss,
Who, gathering the seven worlds, proclaims in a lofty, melodious voice through the whole realm of the earth,
The Self-Existent (Brahmā), born of the lotus, who gives commands to humankind, has fallen asleep.
For you who possess the ten powers, it is always the earliest dawn.

Dwelling on the face of the eastern mountain's peak, overpowering all with its red light,
Destroyer of the masses of darkness, the one eye of all creatures,
That sun too, reeling with intoxication, has wholly fallen asleep.
You who possess the ten powers are always awake at the earliest hour.

The hare-marked one (the moon), whose rays are white, cool, and clear as an elephant's tusk,
Who is beautiful as the ornament on the brow of night, the crest jewel of all,
That one too, bereft of its fading glow, has wholly fallen asleep.
You who possess the ten powers are always awake at the earliest hour.

Supreme, four-armed, with his faces turned to the quarters, half of half of sixteen,
Who knows the rites of recitation and of atonement, and recites the Vedas and their exegesis,
That Brahmā too, born of the stainless lotus, falls into deep sleep.
You who possess the ten powers are always awake at the earliest hour.

Dwelling on the peak of the snowy mountain, wearing a serpent as his sacred thread,
He who had the power to burn the Triple City, who wears a garment of tiger skin,
He whose emblem is the trident (Śiva) has fallen asleep together with the daughter of the supreme mountain (Pārvatī).
You who possess the ten powers are always awake at the earliest hour.

Bearing the blazing vajra in his hand, hard for the asuras to overcome,
The chief of the gods, the lord of Śacī (Indra), reels with a deluded mind;
Asleep by night and by day, he is sunk deep in the mire of desire.

You who possess the ten powers are always awake at the earliest hour.

Blue as the petals of the blue lotus, with wide eyes white as lotuses,
Who has vanquished all the chiefs of the asuras, the maker of all, of manifold forms,
Viṣṇu too has long been asleep, and has not escaped the dwelling of the womb.
For you who possess the ten powers, it is always the earliest dawn.

He who has a mass of tawny matted locks, who is red and copper-hued, with blood-red eyes,
Who had the power to break the single-minded passion of Paśupati (Śiva) in his hour of joy,
That fire god, Agni, whose body burns under the sway of the god of desire (Kāma), he too has fallen asleep.
You who possess the ten powers are always awake at the earliest hour.

White as the moon, as snow, as the white water lily, his eyes reddened from drinking wine,
Unwavering in his desires, a gallant, ever eager to grip the plow in his hand,
That Mighty One (Balarāma), embracing Revatī about the neck, lies sleeping here.
You who possess the ten powers are always awake at the earliest hour.

Elephant-faced, his tusk bared, who creates obstructions in every way,
Both his cheeks streaming with the ichor of rut, where the bees hum loud and clear,
Gaṇapati (Gaṇeśa) too is utterly drunk from drinking wine.
You who possess the ten powers are always awake at the earliest hour.

He in whose fine hand is held a short spear, blue as the flax flower,
With a body like a fresh lotus, Ṣaṇmukha (the six-faced Kārttikeya), slayer of the asura Krauñca,
Three-eyed, in the form of a youth, he too has sunk into deep sleep.
You who possess the ten powers are always awake at the earliest hour.

Greatly attached to food, their bodies wasted, ever taking joy in yoga,
Beset by harms of many kinds, their bodies scorched like hungry ghosts,
Those naked ascetics, who live apart from companions, allies, and other beings, they too are asleep.
You who possess the ten powers are always awake at the earliest hour.

Here in this great sacred place in the borderlands, the sages Bhṛgu and Aṅgiras,
The wandering ascetics and the rest, Vasiṣṭha, Vyāsa, Vālmīki, and Rāma,
Deluded and attached to the loins of young women, they too have fallen asleep.
You who possess the ten powers are always awake at the earliest hour.

Yama, Varuṇa, Kubera, the yakṣas, the spirits, and the lords of the mahoragas,
And likewise the other world protectors, who dwell in the domain of the gods, on the earth, and in the sky,
Lusting after young women and glancing at them sidelong, they too have fallen asleep.
You who possess the ten powers are always awake at the earliest hour.

Sunk in the ocean of existence, their bodies wrapped in the net of delusion,
The sages Kapila and Kaṇāda, forever wandering in circles, with foolish minds,
Who have wholly lost the bliss of peace, they too have fallen asleep.
You who possess the ten powers are always awake at the earliest hour.

When, in the dark night of ignorance, wrapped in the thick bedclothes of craving,
Beings have sunk into the deepest sleep upon the pillow of sense objects,
And toss and turn among the fruits of virtue and nonvirtue,
Homage to the one who is ever awake amid their sleep.

At the water's edge a hundred herds of cattle drink the water,
And though they go away sated, no lessening of the water can be seen.
So too, though a hundred poets have rightly praised the Sage,
The ocean of his qualities, that great treasury of excellence, will never be exhausted.

By praising you, who alone at the full dawn have opened the eye of wisdom,
May the Protector of the Three Worlds, with the light of the seven-horsed sun, ever illumine these beings;
Gaining the various paths and turned back from the evil paths, may they enjoy the works of prosperous glory
And, without fear, freely and with ease, accomplishments of every kind.

The Praise of the Earliest Dawn to the perfect and complete Buddha, by Śrī Harṣadeva, king of Kashmir, is complete.

It was translated by the Indian preceptor, the paṇḍita Rājaśrījñānamitra, and the translator Kheu Gé Yönten Pal.

Translator's Notes

• In the stanza on Agni, the phrase rendered "whose body burns under the sway of the god of desire" is obscure in the Tibetan, and the rendering is tentative.
The "great sacred place in the borderlands" where the sages sleep is not otherwise identified in the text.
Two apparent copyist's slips are read in their evident sense: in the stanza on the world protectors, a misdivided syllable is read as "in the domain of the gods, on the earth," as in the first stanza; and in the stanza on Indra, a variant spelling is read as the name of his consort Śacī.
• The author's name, transcribed in the colophon as Hariśa, is taken as Śrī Harṣadeva, the king of Kashmir to whom this praise is ascribed.
In the closing verse, the Protector of the Three Worlds may be the Buddha or the sun itself; the compressed Tibetan allows either reading.
"Rāja" in the Indian translator's name may be a title ("king of paṇḍitas") rather than part of the name; the name is given as the Tibetan spells it.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.